Project Management Handbook

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1 Purpose and Scope

This chapter covers purpose and scope for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

1.1 How to use this handbook

Smaller projects shall apply a graded approach and document which sections they tailor and why. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved.

Every project with a total estimated cost over $500,000 must follow this handbook in full. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk.

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1.2 Which projects it applies to

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2 Roles and Responsibilities

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2.1 Project lead

The project lead shall hold a weekly meeting with the team and keep a written action log. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes.

Conflicts between project needs and line management direction must be escalated to the program manager within two working days. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting.

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Line managers remain responsible for the people assigned to the project and their training. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule.

The project lead is accountable for scope, schedule, cost, safety and quality of the project. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved.

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2.2 Program manager and sponsor

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3 Initiation and the Project Charter

This chapter covers initiation and the project charter for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

3.1 Writing the charter

The project lead must confirm that required safety and security reviews are identified in the charter. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule.

Success criteria shall be measurable and agreed with the sponsor in writing. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes.

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A signed project charter is required before any funds are committed. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes.

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4 Planning: Scope, Work Breakdown and Schedule

This chapter covers planning: scope, work breakdown and schedule for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

4.1 Scope statement

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4.4 Critical path and float

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4.5 Baselines

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5 Cost Estimating and Budget Management

This chapter covers cost estimating and budget management for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

5.1 Estimating methods

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Charging time or materials to the wrong project is prohibited and must be corrected and reported immediately. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding.

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6 Earned Value and Performance Reporting

This chapter covers earned value and performance reporting for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

6.1 Planned value, earned value and actual cost

Projects over $2 million must report earned value monthly. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed.

The project lead must brief the sponsor before a threshold breach appears in a formal report. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting.

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6.2 Variance thresholds

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6.3 Monthly reports

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7 Risk and Opportunity Management

This chapter covers risk and opportunity management for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

7.1 Identifying risks

High risks must have a mitigation plan with dates and must be reviewed every month. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies.

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New risks identified by any team member shall be added to the register within one week. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting.

The project lead must never remove a risk from the register without recording why it was closed. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes.

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Every project shall maintain a risk register with an owner, likelihood, impact and response for each risk. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people

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7.2 Scoring and ranking

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7.3 Mitigation plans

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8 Safety and Conduct of Operations in Projects

This chapter covers safety and conduct of operations in projects for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

8.1 Integrating safety into planning

A pre-job brief is required before any field or laboratory work that involves hazards. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding.

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Safety requirements shall be planned into the schedule, not added after the fact. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding.

Incidents and near misses must be reported to line management the same day. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule.

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Any worker may stop work they believe is unsafe; the project lead must support that decision and never retaliate. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule.

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9 Quality Assurance and Configuration Management

This chapter covers quality assurance and configuration management for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

9.1 Quality planning

Design changes must be reviewed and approved through configuration control before they are implemented. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved.

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9.2 Reviews and inspections

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10 Stakeholder Communication

This chapter covers stakeholder communication for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

10.1 Mapping stakeholders

Bad news must be communicated early and in person or by phone, followed by a written summary. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later.

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10.2 Communication plans

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10.3 Difficult conversations

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10.4 Customer updates

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11 Procurement and Subcontracts

This chapter covers procurement and subcontracts for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

11.1 Planning procurements

Gifts or favors from vendors are prohibited regardless of value. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed.

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Project staff must not direct subcontractors outside the terms of their contract. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding.

Subcontractor safety performance must be reviewed at least quarterly. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies.

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Procurement lead times shall be built into the schedule before the baseline is approved. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved.

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11.3 Subcontractor oversight

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12 Export Control, Security and Information Handling

This chapter covers export control, security and information handling for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

12.1 Export-controlled information

Foreign national visits and collaborations shall be approved in advance. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes.

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12.3 Classified and controlled unclassified information

Foreign national visits and collaborations shall be approved in advance. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later.

Suspected security incidents must be reported immediately; do not investigate on your own. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations.

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The project lead must obtain an export control determination before sharing technical data outside the Laboratory. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes.

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13 Change Control

This chapter covers change control for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

13.1 What counts as a change

Change requests shall describe the reason, impacts and alternatives considered. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved.

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14 Leading the Project Team

This chapter covers leading the project team for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

14.1 Setting expectations

Retaliation against anyone who raises a concern is prohibited. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations.

The project lead must watch for sustained overtime and rebalance work rather than accept burnout. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations.

Performance concerns must be raised privately and early, and shared with the employee's line manager. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes.

The project lead shall set clear expectations for each team member's role and deliverables. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later.

Conflicts between team members should be addressed directly by the project lead before they affect the work. A common failure mode is treating this as a one-time task instead of something revisited as the project changes. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk.

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14.2 Feedback and coaching

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14.3 Conflict on the team

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14.4 Workload and burnout

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14.5 Recognizing good work

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Conflicts between team members should be addressed directly by the project lead before they affect the work. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. New project leads often underestimate how long this takes, so build time for it into the schedule.

The project lead must watch for sustained overtime and rebalance work rather than accept burnout. Teams that do this well usually keep a short checklist and review it in their weekly meeting. When in doubt, the project lead should ask the program office or the subject matter expert before proceeding. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk.

Retaliation against anyone who raises a concern is prohibited. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations.

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15 Closeout and Lessons Learned

This chapter covers closeout and lessons learned for project leads and project managers. Read it with the requirements in your project's charter and the facility procedures that apply to your work.

15.1 Completing deliverables

A lessons-learned session is required for every project, and results shall be shared with the program office. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk. The intent is not paperwork for its own sake; it is to make sure decisions are visible and can be reviewed. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies.

A project shall not be closed until all deliverables are accepted in writing. Experience across the Laboratory shows that projects that skip this step spend more time recovering than they saved. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. Where this section conflicts with a facility-specific procedure, the more restrictive requirement applies.

Open purchase orders and charge codes must be closed within 60 days of completion. In practice, this means the project lead plans for it from the start rather than reacting later. Examples from recent projects show that early, honest communication avoided most escalations. This requirement exists because problems found late are far more expensive and can put people at risk.

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15.2 Financial closeout

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15.3 Lessons learned

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